

THE GOD OF WHAT'S LEFT

TEXT: Joel 2:15-27 (NKJV) *“Blow the trumpet in Zion, Consecrate a fast, Call a sacred assembly; ¹⁶ Gather the people, Sanctify the congregation, Assemble the elders, Gather the children and nursing babes; Let the bridegroom go out from his chamber, And the bride from her dressing room. ¹⁷ Let the priests, who minister to the LORD, Weep between the porch and the altar; Let them say, “Spare Your people, O LORD, And do not give Your heritage to reproach, That the nations should rule over them. Why should they say among the peoples, Where is their God?”” ¹⁸ Then the LORD will be zealous for His land, And pity His people. ¹⁹ The LORD will answer and say to His people, “ Behold, I will send you grain and new wine and oil, And you will be satisfied by them; I will no longer make you a reproach among the nations. ²⁰*

“ But I will remove far from you the northern army, And will drive him away into a barren and desolate land, With his face toward the eastern sea And his back toward the western sea; His stench will come up, And his foul odor will rise, Because he has done monstrous things.” ²¹ Fear not, O land; Be glad and rejoice, For the LORD has done marvelous things! ²² Do not be afraid, you beasts of the field; For the open pastures are springing up, And the tree bears its fruit; The fig tree and the vine yield their strength. ²³ Be glad then, you children of Zion, And rejoice in the LORD your God; For He has given you the former rain faithfully, And He will cause the rain to come down for you — The former rain, And the latter rain in the first month. ²⁴ The threshing floors shall be full of wheat, And the vats shall overflow with new wine and oil. ²⁵ “ So I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten, The crawling locust, The

consuming locust, And the chewing locust,
My great army which I sent among you. ²⁶
You shall eat in plenty and be satisfied,
And praise the name of the LORD your
God, Who has dealt wondrously with you;
And My people shall never be put to shame.
²⁷ *Then you shall know that I am in the*
midst of Israel: I am the LORD your God
And there is no other. My people shall
never be put to shame.”

INTRO: Please know that I am very much aware of the context of this passage of Scripture. The Prophet Joel speaks this prophecy to Judah in a time of national, moral, and economic crisis. The prophet admonishes his nation and the church to turn to God in repentance. He declares that if they are willing to do so, Jehovah will restore to them everything the enemy has stolen, with interest! Interestingly enough, this prophecy found its final fulfillment on the Day of Pentecost.

The point I want to make here is this: The people of Judah were supposed to be the worshippers, and worshippers have the ability to get closer to God than do others.

Why is it that true worshippers seem to get closer to God than anyone else? They know how to go beyond seeking the hand of God to knowing the heart of God. ***“God made known His acts to the Children of Israel, He made known His ways to Moses.”***

When one is permitted to know the heart of God he automatically receives everything he needs from the hand of God! Matthew 6:33 (NKJV) ***“But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things shall be added to you.”***

It should go without saying worshippers have a better chance than anyone of receiving God's best!

Even though the children of Judah were natural worshippers, they had allowed the enemy to come in and wreak havoc in their lives and leave them in a position of poverty and spiritual decay. The picture being painted here of the condition of the people of Judah is alarming to say the least.

The amazing thing is, though the people had walked away from the Lord, the Lord had not forsaken the people. He will never forsake His people! Hebrews 13:5 (NKJV) ***“For He Himself has said, “I will never leave you nor forsake you.”*** Pay attention to the quotation marks in this verse. The writer of Hebrews is not speaking for himself; he is quoting God and God said ***I will NEVER leave you, nor will I ever forsake you!” “God has never abandoned anyone.”***

I. THE ENEMY IS BENT ON DESTRUCTION...

In case there is any doubt in anyone's mind today let me set the record straight: God wants you blessed and the enemy wants you cursed:

- There are two opposing views...
- There are two opposite agendas...
- There are two very different results...
- The consequences are very different...

With the people of Judah, the enemy had totally decimated them. He had taken them to new lows and accosted them at every level. These were the people of God! They were the worshippers! God's promise to Judah was that He would bless them from what was left!

Just because we were raised in church and have a lengthy spiritual genealogy does not mean we are exempt to falling into the traps of the enemy!

The lives of the worshippers of Judah were in a sad state of disrepair. The enemy appeared to be winning the war! But there was something left and God was going to use it to get Judah blessed beyond belief!

The agenda of the enemy is very clear. John 10:10 (AMP) “***The thief comes only in order to steal and kill and destroy. I came that they may have and enjoy life, and have it in abundance (to the full, till it overflows).***”

Even though the enemy may have brought all kinds of hell into our lives, the constant pattern of God’s activity in the life of the believer is rescue! Make no mistake about it; He is the God of what’s left!

Trust me, we may feel that we have squandered every opportunity that has been afforded, but He is the God of what’s left!

All we have to do is give Him what's left and He will shock us in turning our situation around.

II. GOD IS BENT ON RESTORATION...

The entire agenda of God is a process of redemption!

- The moment Adam sinned God rolled out a plan of redemption...
- Adams fall may have caught Adam by surprise but it did not catch God by surprise... When Adam sinned God did not roll out “Plan B” He rolled out “Plan A!” God was going to take what was left and kick the daylights out of Lucifer, then rub his nose in it by populating Heaven with what was left!
- Throughout the Old Testament God was offering restoration to sinful people....
- The New Testament is initiated with the announcement of a savior...

If you are in any doubt about the motives of God, let me settle it for you once and for all! John 3:16 (NKJV) ***“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”*** 2 Peter 3:9 (NKJV) ***“The Lord is not slack concerning His promise, as some count slackness, but is longsuffering toward us, not willing that any should perish but that all should come to repentance.”***

The intentions of God are unmistakable with regard to Judah and with regard to us: He wants to make something of what's left!

III. GOD CAN WORK WITH WHAT'S LEFT...

Though our lives have been almost completely destroyed by the battering ram of life, there is no doubt about it; God can work with what's left!

When an automobile has been in an accident, the place for the car is a body shop. One body shop had as it's slogan "*We fix wrecks!*" That should be the heart of every church. Most people who come to Christ have been:

- Wrecked like a wretch...
- Beat up from the feet up...
- Tore up from the floor up...
- Messed up from the neck up...
- Broken from the dopin'...
- Reeling from a relationship...

I do not know many people who came to Christ until they had been wrecked!

Some ministries and churches only want the up-and-outers; they do not want to mess with the down-and-outers! Have you ever followed a car that was running down the road cockeyed? Someone took the car to the wrong body shop! When we see a person whose life is cockeyed we can be pretty

confident, they have been fixed by the wrong source! They stopped at the wrong church! (I mean body shop!)

I have been known to drive across the city to get to a great restaurant and I would drive across this city to be in a powerful Pentecostal church that believes in and demonstrates the power of God!

When Lot chose the well-watered plain of Jordan, Abraham was consigned to what was left. What was left was a land that was not very productive! (Some of you have been assigned the leftovers!)

Lot took the best land for himself in spite of the fact the wicked cities of Sodom and Gomorrah were located there. If you think Lot did not know what the risks were, you are wrong! The Word said, “***He pitched his tent toward Sodom.***” The end result of

Lot's decision was a total train wreck! He found himself tethered to::

- A dead wife...
- A drinking problem...
- An incestuous relationship with his daughter... (Because of the alcohol... I do not know of one redeeming quality about alcohol that cannot be accomplished another way!)
- He became the father of two inbred, evil nations - Moab and Ammon...

Parents, grandparents, church leaders, saints, listen to the heart of this preacher today; it does not pay to pitch your tent toward Sodom! What does pitching your tent toward Sodom look like in our lives?

- Spending inferior amounts of time in the Word and prayer...
- Pursuing riches at the expense of our spiritual walk...
- Allowing things in our homes that are not pleasing to the Lord... (What I allow

in His house – He will allow in my house) (What we do in moderation – Our children will do to excess)

- Allowing our families to prioritize sports and education above the need to be connected at the church...
- Placing ministry on the shelf as we pursue our careers and temporal success...

There are some of you in this building today that are going to pay for pitching your tent toward Sodom with your children and grandchildren. What I want to know is, are we prepared to pay the heavy price for loose living! (Mark & Pam Brown)

In case my warning against pitching your tent toward Sodom has come a little late, I want you to know He is the God of what's left!

Abraham was relegated to what was left from Lot's original decision. God turned an inferior, lack-luster land into a Land of Promise, and caused it to ***“Flow with milk and honey”*** with what was left! The desolate piece of land that Abraham got left with is responsible for most of the political turmoil in the world today. Every nation in the Middle East wants to own the Promised Land! Nobody wants to own Sodom!

I dare us to give God what's left! He is the God of what's left!

In pursuit of a new and anointed King for Israel, the prophet Samuel inspected the seven sons of Jesse. When the Lord rejected all of Jesse's seven sons, the prophet Samuel said ***“Is this all of your sons?”*** Jesse said, ***“I have one left but he is a teenager and a shepherd!”*** God took what was left and:

- Turned a nation around spiritually...
- Turned a nation around financially...

- Transitioned the land from war to peace...
- Prepared and resourced the people to build Him a house of worship...

He is the God of what's left!

God gave Gideon 32,000 fighting men and told him to annihilate the Midianites and the Amalekites. Before they could go to war God told Gideon ***“Let everyone who is afraid, go home.”*** Gideon said goodbye to 22,000 men (Using the word men loosely). God said, ***“You still have too many men. Take them to the brook and those who drink like dogs, send them home.”*** Gideon lost 9,700 more soldiers! Gideon is left with:

- 300 fighting men...
- Each man had a trumpet...
- Each man had a pitcher with a lantern inside...

- Each man was to shout “***The sword of the Lord and of Gideon***” and break the pitcher and lantern...

The Lord took Gideon’s little army and completely destroyed the innumerable host of the Midianites and Amalekites! He is the God of what’s left!

God anointed Samson to take the jawbone of a donkey and kill a thousand Philistines!

When the battle was over and Samson was about to faint from dehydration God hollowed out a place in the donkey’s jawbone, filled it with water, and quenched Samson’s thirst!

He is surely the God of what’s left!

Elijah asked the widow “***What do you have left?***” She said, “***Just enough meal and oil for one more meal for my son and me, we are going to eat it and die!***” The Prophet

said, “*Make me a cake first out of what’s left.*” She gave what was left to God and He sustained the widow, her son, and Elijah during the time of the famine! The oil and mill remained! He is the God of what’s left!

At eighty years old all Moses had left was a speech impediment and a shepherds rod! He had gone from the king’s house to the outhouse! He gave his life and his rod to God, and it is amazing what the Lord was able to do through this willing vessel! He is the God of what’s left!

CONCLUSION:

God can:

- Make a saint from the sinner with what’s left...
- Turn a broken heart into a hopeful heart with what’s left...
- Turn financial disaster into a financial success with what’s left...

- Put a family back together out of what's left...
- He can turn a house into a home with what's left...
- Turn an unhealthy body into the picture of health with what's left... (If a doctor can practice medicine on what's left, don't you think God can do a healing on what's left?)
- Build an unbelievable church with what's left... (The slogan of the church should be "*We fix wrecks!*")

He is the God of what's left!